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GOTHIC TROPES IN THE HARRY POTTER UNIVERSE

***GÓTIKUS TOPOSZOK A HARRY POTTER
UNIVERZUMBAN***

BA Thesis

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VI. Tudományterületi és kurzusspecifikus szabályozás

A különböző tudományterületek sajátosságaira tekintettel a karok ösztönzik a tanszékeket és programfelelősöket, hogy a jelen ajánlással összhangban dolgozzák ki saját MI-használati irányelveiket. Az oktatók hatáskörébe tartozik, hogy a mesterséges intelligencia alkalmazásának pontos módját a kurzushoz igazítsák és erről a hallgatókat már az első oktatási alkalom során tájékoztassák.

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Abbreviations of book titles:

Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone: HPPS

Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets: HPCHS

Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban: HPPA

Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire: HPGF

Harry Potter and the Order of the Phoenix: HPOP

Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince: HPHBP

Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: HPDH

Introduction

Gothic is a genre with recurring elements, a literary tradition that shows us the darkest depths of human psyche, utilising haunted castles (Jerrold E. Hogle 6), monsters and often blurs the borders between life and death, reality, visions and dreams (19). This thesis explores how Gothic tropes are used in the Harry Potter volumes, analysing their nature and narrative function. Although the Harry Potter books are marketed as children's books by Bloomsbury, they abound in Gothic tropes. The Harry Potter universe draws from the Scottish mythology and the Gothic literary tradition, and as a genius and prolific author, J. K. Rowling consciously employs these Gothic elements, not merely for the sake of aesthetic spookiness, but as pedagogic tools to confront readers with the harsh reality of grief, death, betrayal, the vulnerability of mortality. Encountering these topics through Harry's lenses creates a safe environment to process them. Building on these tropes provide complexity and depth to the coming-of-age story of the young wizard.

Since a bachelor's thesis has word limitations, this paper is not an exhaustive collection of Gothic tropes of all the seven Harry Potter volumes. Instead, it highlights some of them arranged into three main chapters. The first chapter explores how isolated places in both the mundane Muggle world and the mysterious Wizarding world contribute to Harry's character development, like the Cupboard under the Stairs, the castle of Hogwarts, Grimmauld Place 12 and the Forbidden Forest. The focus shifts from isolation towards liminality and haunting experiences in the second chapter, where ghostly places, such as the sublime Veil in the Ministry, the Riddle's Graveyard and Moaning Myrtle's bathroom are explored. The third chapter observes the nature of villainy and monstrosity, highlighting Bellatrix as the Madwoman, Dark Mentor and Anti-Mother, and the ultimate Gothic Double, Voldemort.

Due to word count constraints, other tropes like Ghosts, Werewolves, Necromancy, Alchemy were not discussed. For example, the Uncanny nature of objects and creatures could have been more thoroughly analysed. Iconic figures, such as Death Eaters and antagonists; the aristocratic but fallen Malfoy family; the Gaunt's legacy; the murdered child, Ariana Dumbledore; the asylum wing in St. Mungo's and many more Gothic elements were omitted, but the selected few tropes illustrate the nature and function of the Gothic elements in the narrative and in Harry's character development.

1. Isolated Places

With the help of fantasy realms, readers can escape reality and discover different, non-existent places that are far away from everyday life. The mood of these imaginary worlds varies greatly, just as the stories are quite diverse within the realm of fantasy, written for different target audiences. Gothic fiction traditionally explores the darker aspects of both the physical world and the human soul. By merging these elements, the genre utilises familiar tropes, such as gloomy, wild settings and secluded locations to mirror the internal struggles of the characters or the flaws within their social structures (Keech 130).

1.1 Isolation in the Mundane World: The Cupboard under the Stairs

The first dark and isolated place we encounter in the Harry Potter universe is the mundane cupboard under the stairs in the Muggle world. The tiny, miserable and windowless cupboard serves as Harry's room in the Dursley's house. Harry is often grounded here without meals (HPPS 36). Although the Dursleys take the baby in, they do not treat him kindly. Harry always remained a persona non grata, an unwelcome outsider within the microcosm of the Dursley family. Harry's outcast status is reinforced by the fact that he is given the worst place possible, a place in the cupboard under the stairs, where families usually store shoes, brooms and less valuable junk that is better not to see. "Perhaps it had something to do with living in a dark cupboard, but Harry had always been small and skinny for his age" (HPPS 21).

According to Chole Germaine Buckley, "twenty-first century children's Gothic fiction begins with a violent act of *un-homing*. Losing parents, home, set adrift to discover an expansive, dangerous Gothic landscape" (Buckley 1, emphasis in the original). Buckley identified a pattern of rescue following Gothic un-homing, which the Harry Potter storyline also follows. Harry must wait eleven years for some justice and freedom. He becomes ready to discover the secret magical world, but before that happens, he needs a guide, a savior: "...a mysterious figure comes to inform the protagonist" (Buckley 1). In Harry's case the mysterious stranger is Hagrid, the school's gamekeeper, who informs him about his true background and reveals other secrets about Harry's abilities. "Harry – yer a wizard" (HPPS 55). From here on, there is no turning back to the Muggle cupboard under the stairs, and Harry becomes a hero.

The cupboard is therefore an isolated starting point that strengthens Harry's attachment to his future friends and surroundings. According to Emily Griesinger, children's fantasy

literature is a tool that conditions readers to cope with the difficulties of the present and works as a reminder to hope for a better future (Griesinger 459), and exactly this aim is shown in the Harry Potter books. Luckily, Harry's mental state is quite healthy, and his behaviour is assertive, sometimes even witty and sassy. Despite all the years of isolation, Harry becomes strong, kind-hearted and friendly, so he is a character with a healthy and functioning moral compass. Claire Schiappa-Burdet wrote an inspirational book about him titled "Act and Think Like Harry Potter". Her work is full of positive examples and suggestions about how worthwhile it is to become a person like Harry. After a terrible start, he matures into a talented, brave, benevolent teenager with true friends (Schiappa-Burdet 127) then becomes an adult man who can find his purpose and fit into the wizarding community.

Consequently, being raised in the cupboard is a temporary isolation that could be left behind and when Harry has an opportunity to step outside, he makes meaningful lifelong friendships. The specific mentioning of the name "The Cupboard under the Stairs" (*HPSS* 36) on Harry's letter makes the document itself a narrative bridge between the Muggle world and the Wizarding world.

1.2. Isolation in the Wizarding World: Secret Places

1.2.1 The Wizarding World

The Wizarding World is an extensive isolated place that overlaps first the British Muggle world, and, as Harry discovers it gradually, the whole Europe and several other continents. It is kept as a closely guarded secret, and a set of intricate rules dictate its existence: the International Statue of Wizarding Secrecy. According to Eva Oppermann, who quotes the French philosopher Michael Foucault, J. K. Rowling's Wizarding world has heterotopian qualities, which means it is outside of the normal world, but in connection with it, and juxtaposes magical and mundane (Muggle) elements, meanwhile operating with its own set of rules. Similar places do exist in our real world as well: boarding schools, ships and military camps for soldiers (Oppermann 2).

We learn most about the English magical world, and especially about certain locations in its capital city, London. The realm of magic can be accessed through secret passages that are invisible to non-magical people because they seem uninteresting, repulsive (Muggle-repelling charms), or simply because they are quite mundane: like a telephone box (*HPOP* 115) or a broken-down pub on Charing Cross Road, from where the Leaky Cauldron and Diagon Alley, the shopping street opens (*HPSS* 73). In comparison with the Muggle world, the Wizarding

World lacks progress and operates as an old-fashioned Gothic enclave; they know about Muggle inventions and technology, yet they refuse to use it.

1.2.2 Hogwarts School of Witchcraft and Wizardry

The ultimate Gothic place within the Wizarding world is the enchanted medieval castle, Harry's new home, which is both a dangerous place and a safe haven at the same time, an externalised projection of Harry's fears and desires. Paradoxically, the secluded, spooky castle is the first place where Harry feels safe, welcomed and at home. As Tamar Heller points out, traditionally, in Gothic literature, this ambivalence between the ideally safe, domestic environment and the threatening fragility of the domestic place (Heller 394) is recurring. However, in most cases, it is the adult female protagonist who is getting trapped in the suffocating domestic place in a patriarchal society, and not a child. Then, the entrapped protagonist tries to escape to the other separate sphere (Heller 395), which is the outside world. In Harry's case, he steps out of the Muggle cupboard to discover a completely different place of isolation.

Hogwarts is a haunted boarding school for young witches and wizards, but other sorts of supernatural creatures also reside in it and not just ghosts and poltergeists. They are "pearly-white and slightly transparent" (*HPPS* 123), they have their own hierarchy and "they cannot walk on earth but float or drift" (Stojilkov 144). The castle has turrets, towers, dungeons, a greenhouse with venomous plants; a lake with a giant squid and the Forbidden Forest, which is a habitat of different beasts. Hogwarts harbors not just deadly creatures and hidden passageways, but it has a rather dark history, including such legends as the altercations between the four Founders, the departure of the blood purity fanatic Salazar Slytherin, who left the school and as a farewell gift, hid an ancient monster, his "pet" basilisk in the castle dungeon. Harry learns about the Founders and the Chamber of Secrets from Professor Binns, a History of Magic Teacher, who is a ghost (*HPCHS* 159).

Hogwarts was founded in the Middle Ages, but magic is even older than the school. It can be inferred from the part when Ron writes a letter in *The Prisoner of Azkaban*, while the Weasley family is having a holiday in Egypt. "Bill's taken us round all the tombs, and you wouldn't believe the curses those old Egyptian izards put on them" (*HPPA* 10). Hogwarts becomes Harry's new home, but it is not merely a Gothic setting. It externalises the inner struggles of Harry, who feels safe here, but the lingering threat of dark forces is always present, and there is a whimsical, blurry line between life and death due to the different types of ghosts and moving portraits of dead headmasters.

In addition to Voldemort, whose dark secrets also contribute to the castle's history, Harry faces numerous dangers within the castle walls and grounds: he encounters dementors (demons that feed on human soul and symbolise depression) (*HPPA* 406), acromantulas (giant spiders that can speak) (*HPCHS* 292), thestrals (bat-like horses that can only be seen by those who have encountered death) (*HPOP* 184), sphynxes (*HPGF* 529), three-headed dogs, (*HPPS* 285), boggarts (*HPPA* 139), et cetera. These creatures have Gothic significance, as they are more than just bio-decorations. They mirror fear, show the macabre vulnerability of life, and are directly tied to the imagination about afterlife. Meeting them and fighting against them are formative points in Harry's character development, and thanks to them the protagonist is becoming increasingly familiar with this rich magical world and can claim it as his own. According to Juha Ridanpaa, "regions are conceived as humanlike individuals" (Rindpaa 191), and if we extend this idea to places like Hogwarts, which is an imaginative and isolated region within the British Wizarding world, we can assume, that Hogwarts castle, like every individual, has its own personality. One example of the whims of the castle is the Room of Requirement, which is a special vanishing room that only appears for those in need. Hogwarts contains tricky staircases with vanishing steps, and hidden passageways that lead to the nearby village of Hogsmeade. Hogwarts is, therefore, a Gothic setting, since important places in Gothic fiction traditionally blur the borders between safe and dangerous, real and unreal (Schroeder 'Real Zombies' 428).

1.2.3 The Magical within the Mundane: Number Twelve, Grimmauld Place

The Black family estate (Sirius's relatives) serves as a Gothic trope, embodying the inescapable nature of inherited family secrets. As a site of moral and physical darkness and gloom, this place suggests that all deeply buried secrets are destined to be discovered and eventually revealed. This decaying house, once the property of Voldemort's followers reflects the moral corruption of its inhabitants through the gloominess and the decorations. Even Kreacher, Sirius's house-elf exists as an extension of this grim environment. He is not just a servant, but a living, breathing relic of the family's dark history, tethered to the house, as a guardian of the Black's secrets. The name of this place employs a phonetic pun that functions as a Gothic signifier, marking the domestic space as inherently grim and old, characterised by darkness and ancestral decay (Nielsen 67). When we got to know this intriguing setting during the fifth book, *The Order of the Phoenix*, it is already quite mouldy and neglected. 12 Grimmauld place is hidden in a Muggle environment, and it is part of a townhouse in central London. It serves as

a headquarters for Dumbledore's followers, the Order of the Phoenix, and becomes Harry's temporary home before he goes back to Hogwarts.

The previous owners' pure-blood ideology is still lingering everywhere inside when Harry arrives, even though the Weasleys try to make the place more friendly, clean and comfortable. 12 Grimmauld place abounds in Gothic elements. Creepy objects, oppressive or cursed relics are placed everywhere, like boggarts hiding in the furniture; a chopped-off, taxidermy house-elf head collection is hanging on the walls. But the most haunting elements are the burned tapestry of the Black family tree and the portrait of Mrs Black. The latter is a loud expression of all the Black family values that screams insults each time someone disturbs her peace. "Stains of dishonour, filthy half-breeds, blood traitors" (*HPOP* 94). These objects, along with the family motto (*Toujours Pur*) give us a deeper insight into the family's ideology. Sirius explains Harry the significance of another key relic, a silent memento of the Black values, which is the family tree tapestry with burned holes that mark the traitors: "small, round, charred holes... rather like a cigarette burn" (*HPOP* 102).

1.2.4 The Forbidden Forest

Alessandra Petrina claims that the name of the Forbidden Forest is "premonitory" (Petrina 11), so it foreshadows the secrets, taboos, monsters, hunts and the terror that await the protagonist later. This subchapter argues that the Forbidden Forest is one of the most important spatial Gothic tropes, and there are several reasons for this. The Forest, which harbors dangerous beasts, provides space for moral juxtaposition between Voldemort's cursed half-life and Harry's good-hearted, mortal human life. It solidifies Harry's moral compass on two essential occasions: when he meets Voldemort alone during his first year, and in the seventh, when he accepts his fate and goes there to get killed by him. Between these two events, the Forest still has many lessons to teach Harry and other characters about their own fears. Rather than running through a tedious chronological list, the following paragraph will prioritise key moments based on their actual weight in Harry's character development.

The biggest pivotal point happens when Harry is in his third year, uses the Time Turner, and wants to save Sirius's life and his own from the dementors. Alessandra Petrina highlights that a clear association can be observed between Harry's heroic wizard story and King Arthur's legends (Petrina 11). Harry, as a capable savior figure, meets something very important in the Forbidden Forest: "his true self" (Petrina 11), when he realises that it is him who conjures the Patronus, and not his father. I argue that this epiphany, when Harry is forced to acknowledge

that he should be the capable protector, and not his dead father, is a crucial Gothic identity-twist, as this act is related to mixing up the dead and alive personalities, fueled by Harry's longing for seeing his father's ghost. Harry accepts the fact that no one is coming, takes agency and identifies with his father's values as a savior. This is when his identity significantly grows as he discovers that he is able to save himself. "And then it hit him – he understood. He hadn't seen his father – he had seen *himself*." (*HPPA* 436 emphasis in the original).

However, Harry encounters creatures in the Forest that are dangerous than the dementors. Harry's second truly face-to-face encounter with Voldemort takes place in the wild, dark Forbidden Forest, when he finds the slayed unicorn and Voldemort appears as a hooded shadow and drinks the innocent creature's blood. "First years should note that the forest in the grounds is forbidden to all pupils. And few of our older students would do well to remember that as well." (*HPSS* 135). Assuming that Fred and George neglected these warnings, and yet they were not expelled, shows that there are certain dangerous boundaries that might be crossed. In fact, the illogicality and cruelty of the school is proved by sending students into the perilous Forest at night, as a form of detention. During their first year, Harry, Ron, Hermione and Malfoy are forced to enter the woods with Hagrid to find an injured unicorn. Draco seems to be the only character who recognises the imminent danger realistically. "I'm not going in that Forest" (*HPSS* 268). "And what if whatever hurt the unicorn finds us first?" (*HPSS* 269). We must remember that the children sent to the Forest at night are only eleven-year-olds, therefore they are not sufficiently trained to defend themselves. The sight that awaits them will be surely shocking, since Hagrid points out that "there is blood all over the place" (*HPSS* 269).

The Gothic atmosphere is further heightened when the group splits up, forcing the children to navigate in the darkness alone. While discovering the dead unicorn in the wilderness, Harry encounters a cloaked figure drinking its blood. It can be considered as a scene of abject horror, an evil deed that violates the natural order. Firenze the centaur saves Harry and explains the despicability of the deed he witnessed. This encounter in the Forest depicts a moral dilemma and solidifies Harry's moral compass. In contrast to his nemesis, Harry chooses mortality and dignity over the corruption of the soul. In this part of the narrative the Forbidden Forest ceases to be just a dark and gloomy death-trap, and functions as a site of lecture, which solidifies Harry's morals. The Forbidden Forest reaches its full potential as a Gothic trope during the Battle of Hogwarts in the seventh book, when it becomes a site of self-sacrifice when Harry dies. His fear and the subsequent encounter with the Adava Kedavra curse emphasize the gothic sublime, where the protagonist must accept his own mortality. According to James F. Scott, Gothic sublime is a combination of terror and awe, something more profound

and complex than just a simply terrifying landscape, because the presence of melancholic beauty is also involved (Scott 366). This experience results in a paradoxical state. Like Schrödinger's cat, Harry is neither alive nor dead. The intermediate situation takes place at King's Cross Station in another dimension.

But not just the protagonist has to face his destiny and his worst fear in the Forbidden Forest. In the fifth book, the cruel Professor Umbridge, who thinks half-breeds are inferior to wizards and witches, is kidnapped and punished by centaurs after entering their territory (*HPOP* 695). In the second book, Ron, who is afraid of spiders, also escapes with Harry from the acromantula's nest (*HPCHS* 292). According to Jonathan W. Thurston, the spider is a predator that violates human boundaries (Thurston 36), triggers instinctive fear (Thurston 37 and 38) because psychologically we are built to have a genuine fear from being eaten alive (36). Not only did Ron walk into a lair of spiders with Harry in order to get the knowledge to save his friends, but he also escaped from acromantulas, which represent even bigger danger than spiders. When Thurston refers to cultural scientist Matt Kaplan, he explains why mythical monsters are even more terrifying than existing predators. It is a combination of three major factors: our instinctive fear that we carry in our DNA, taxonomy (the shape of the predators) and the fear of the unknown. Harry and Ron learn that it was not Hagrid who opened the Chamber of Secrets, and they realise that the giant acromantula might be the gamekeeper's friend, but not theirs, and the boys can barely escape from the nest. The name of the leader acromantula is Aragog and he can talk. Nilsen highlights that Rowling consciously picked this name for monster that refers to spiders, and the creature is personified, since Aragog is not only able to speak human language, but he also possesses human emotions, like fondness and trust for Hagrid (Nielsen 64), yet he is delighted to give Hagrid's friends, Harry and Ron, to his offsprings as self-delivered food since the boys came willingly to their nest (*HPCHS* 295).

Essentially, isolated places in the Harry Potter universe can be mundane cupboards, intriguing castles, decaying ancestral homes of dark wizards and gloomy, predator-packed forests, but they are not mere Gothic decorations, not just beautiful, spooky ambiances. All these functions as catalysts, agents of change, triggering Harry's moral, heroic evolution. But to understand his development better, we must explore liminal spaces more deeply, since those are the rites of passage in the protagonist's life.

2. Ghostly Places

Hogwarts is a haunted castle, but the Harry Potter volumes abound in much more perilous places where the protagonist witnesses the stark reality of death with his naked eyes, and

encounters unexplainable mysteries related to the scenes. In this chapter I would like to highlight three of these classic Gothic elements, which were employed in a modern fantasy setting: two liminal spaces related to death, and a graveyard. The whispering Veil in the Ministry represents the sublime threshold between life and death. Moaning Myrtle's bathroom is the other liminal space within Hogwarts, providing a narrative bridge between the castle and the Chamber of Secrets, and functions as an important point in Harry's investigation. The macabre Riddle Graveyard belongs to a decaying old manor and becomes the place of rebirth of Voldemort, expressing the return of the repressed horrors.

2.1 The Veil

Liminality means in-betweenness. The origin of the name is Latin (meaning threshold), and it can represent a cognitive or a physical passage, a doorway, which is important for both character development and narrative actions. A liminal space is not a Gothic trope per se; however, Rowling created a special liminal gate that evolved into a trope because it is a sublime border between life and death. Christen McQuinn's scholarly article is the spine of my second chapter, as she reinforces the idea of a connection between physical, mental, biological and spatial liminality. She points out that adolescence is the most striking example of this anxiety-filled transitional phase, which brings about important changes (McQuinn 14). A liminal space functions as a rite of passage in the genre of Bildungsroman, where a character changes, evolves into a more mature person, and this transformation is an important step towards reaching the character's full potential. McQuinn states that fantasy and children's literature often use liminality that is very explicit: actual doors, gates and portals (14). In the Harry Potter universe, the first liminal place that Harry encounters is the mysterious Platform 9 $\frac{3}{4}$ at King's Cross Station.

There is a Gothic twist related to liminal spaces in Rowling's fantasy world, which leads to identity-loss. In McQuinn's article there is a statement about the possibility of losing one's identity in a transitional space. "Identity is found or evolves in one's liminal space, but it can also be lost if care is not taken" (McQuinn 17). The first identity-loss in relation to Harry happens during Harry's third year, when the dementors appear on the train and he faints. Luckily, the process of losing his identity (his soul) is not complete, otherwise Harry would have been dead. The same sort of almost-identity-loss due to dementors reoccurs at the end of the third book when both Harry and Sirius nearly die. Sirius's final identity-loss, which is

irrevocable, takes place in the fifth book when Harry's godfather disappears behind the Veil in the Ministry.

The whispering Veil is the most enigmatic Gothic liminal space in the seven volumes, which introduces the experience of the sublime. In the thirty-fourth chapter as Harry and his friends enter the Ministry to save Sirius, they see an unusual archway. "[T]here was a raised stone dais in the centre of the pit, on which stood a stone archway that looked so ancient, cracked and crumbling that Harry was amazed the thing was still standing. Unsupported by any surrounding wall, the archway was hung with a tattered black curtain or veil, which despite the complete stillness of the cold surrounding air, was fluttering very slightly as though it had just been touched" (*HPOP* 711). This is the place where a chapter later Sirius disappears, and from which he never returns. But his death remains a conundrum.

Stojilkov highlights the similarities between the Veil and the Barzakh (the Islamic concept of a line between worlds), and states that the Barzakh could be the inspiration for this chapter, as within the Wizarding world, there is a secret and mysterious realm that separates the living from the deceased (Stojilkov 142). By invoking this concept, the narrative moves beyond simple fantasy and enters the territory of ontological liminality, depicting the archway as a barrier that is equally spiritual and physical. "The literal meaning of the word Barzakh is a veil or barrier that stands between two things, and which does not allow the two to meet" (Stojilkov 142), like Harry and Sirius, who cannot meet after the latter disappears.

Previously it is also mentioned that Harry felt a strange, unexplainable feeling as if someone was very close to him, someone invisible, on the other side of the Veil, and he had a sudden urge to go through the beautiful archway. The Veil lured him like a siren song. Strange "whispering and murmuring noises" (*HPOP* 712) were coming from the other side of the tattered cloth and only Luna and Harry hear it, Hermione did not. It could be explained by the fact that only they can see the thestrals: Harry and Luna have already seen someone dying (*HPOP* 184). The Veil is the perfect Gothic trope because it is ambivalent, terrifying and beautiful at the same time. It teaches Harry that there are things in the Wizarding Worlds that are beyond human comprehension, dangerous things and forces, that should not be provoked.

Adding to the mystery is the fact that we do not know exactly what happened to Sirius physically, other than he fell through a ghostly curtain-like substance. Stojilkov also mentions that Harry's godfather, "Sirius falls the veil, having been struck by Bellatrix Lestrange's killing curse" (Stojilkov 143). I would contradict this statement, since there is no explicit curse type mentioned in the text. Taking it into consideration that the Adava Kedavra, the killing curse has an iconic "green light" (*HPGF* 536), (*HPHBP* 556) (*HPDH* 43, 280, 575), and Bellatrix tries

to hinder Sirius with “a jet of red light” (*HPOP* 741), we cannot state that Bellatrix killed her cousin and pushed Sirius through the archway to the world of whispering spirits. Before losing his balance, Sirius was attacked by Bellatrix with multiple Cruciatus curses. The Cruciatus, which is another type of the three Unforgivables, is signified by a red light. Despite the fact that Bellatrix did not shoot Sirius with the Killing curse, she let out a “triumphant scream” (*HPOP* 741) while watching her cousin fall beyond the Veil.

Some characters like Remus Lupin seem to know more about the nature of the Veil, but this knowledge is unfortunately not explained further. What Lupin knows is shared mostly through his actions when he stops Harry before the boy could reach the archway, trying to save his godfather. Harry was told not to do anything, because Sirius is simply irrevocably “gone” (*HPOP* 742). The members of the Order of the Phoenix did not double-check the archway, and no further investigation was mentioned in the books. So, the nature of Sirius’s death, like the Veil itself, remains a mystery. Later Nearly Headless Nick, the resident ghost of the Gryffindor-house teaches Harry an important lesson related to death. He talks about two different paths: the majority of deceased people accept their death and leave the realm of the living behind, but there are some spirits like him, who are afraid of dying and remain among the living. Harry asks him about the reason why Sirius did not return as a ghost, hoping desperately to see his godfather again, but Nick’s honest but vague answer infuriates him. “‘He will not come back’, repeated Nick. ‘He will have... gone on.’” (*HPOP* 792). He states that, unfortunately, he does not know much about the secrets related to death, since he is “neither here nor there” (*HPOP* 792). Nick’s melancholic liminal existence is a Gothic element, he represents the less likeable approach towards mortality, and Rowling consciously reinforces the notion that Harry’s parents and Sirius did not return as constantly lingering ghosts but accepted their fate and died with dignity. Consequently, after seeing Snape’s memories (tears), and realising that he was groomed to sacrifice himself, Harry steels himself, surrenders and accepts his fate. He behaves heroically and is ready to die for saving everyone else. He deliberately goes alone to the Forbidden Forest and sacrifices himself. After this crucial moment, in the thirty-fifth chapter’s parallel-universe King’s Cross scene, he finds himself in the ultimate Gothic liminality: between life and death. By choosing mortality, Harry goes back to the battlefield out of his own volition, which illustrates that true power lies not in defying death (Voldemort’s approach), but in embracing it.

2.2 The Riddle House's Graveyard

Located in the village of Little Hangleton (*HPGF* 1), the Riddle House's Graveyard is a traditional Gothic setting: a decaying, unsettling and neglected cemetery, shunned by the villagers alongside with the manor it belongs to. The Riddles were Voldemort's relatives from his father's side, and the cemetery of their house becomes a place for a dark resurrection ritual in the fourth book. The author consciously places a yew tree to a centre of attention that immediately catches Harry's eyes upon arrival (*HPGF* 535). According to *The Yew-Trees of Great Britain and Ireland*, the toxic yew tree was used in funeral rites. It symbolises immortality in Scottish folklore, but it is also a symbol of death and resurrection (Lowe 2), since it can regrow from fallen branches. Voldemort's wand is also made of yew (*HPPS* 92). Placing a yew tree into a graveyard that draws the attention of Harry is an excellent tool for foreshadowing the imminent danger that awaits the protagonist. In chapter thirty-two, Harry and Cedric are transported here with a secret portkey, the Triwizard Cup, and the graveyard turns quickly into a place of murder, as Harry witnesses Cedric's death (*HPGF* 536).

It is also a place of confinement, when Harry is tied with conjured ropes to Voldemort's father's marble headstone (*HPGF* 537). Being resurrected, Voldemort summons his Death Eaters and tried to murder him in front of a bloodthirsty audience in the cemetery (*HPGF* 553), and he wants Harry's execution to be a show, an entertainment. Voldemort's intentions become quite clear as he addresses the entrapped Harry as his "guest of honour" and his resurrection ritual as his "rebirthing party" (*HPGF* 548). When he gives him back his wand (*HPGF* 554), it is a false pretence of a fair gentlemanly duel. What Voldemort really wants is to eradicate Harry's reputation in front of his cronies. Killing a fourteen-year-old without giving him the chance to defend himself would be a pathetic deed, and he wants everyone to feel that Harry is not a real opponent for him, the Potter boy was just purely lucky when he survived the Killing curse. "“You see, I think, how foolish it was to suppose that this boy could ever have been stronger than me”" (*HPGF* 553).

Regarding the dark resurrection ritual, Ranita Chatterjee argues that death is not a Gothic topic per se, but the blur between being dead or alive is (Chatterjee 1), and this is why the Riddle's Graveyard is the most important liminal space for Voldemort: he is able to transform from the weaker form, from "perverted, foetus-like creature" (Chatterjee 1) into a powerful humanoid entity, this time without possessing someone. The third chapter will give deeper analysis of Voldemort's appearance and importance, so this subchapter will concentrate solely on the setting and its relation to the Gothic and its narrative function. The gloomy graveyard serves as a tragic milestone in Harry's life, most importantly because he sees his

schoolmate die. This traumatic experience teaches him about the harsh reality of mortality that even good-hearted people can die anytime. Cedric's death is a collateral damage, unexpected, sudden and completely pointless. What makes it even worse is that Harry feels responsible for Diggory's demise since it was he who initiated that they should grab the Cup together at the end of the tournament (*HPGF* 534), because Harry wanted to be fair. Little did he know that the Cup was a portkey to the Riddle's graveyard in disguise, so the trap was set for Harry. Cedric's murder was completely avoidable.

Furthermore, additionally to the psychological trauma, Harry gets wounded with a dagger (*HPGF* 540) and forced to contribute to the dark ritual with his pure, protecting blood. Harry's blood becomes a crucial tool in Voldemort's resurrection, along with many impure, off-putting ingredients, such as Wormtail's hand, which is mutilated by himself, or the exhumed bones of Voldemort's dead father (*HPGF* 539). Digging up bones from graves, knowing the fact that a cemetery is a sacred space, means a profound desecration. So, Harry realises that unwillingly he was part of the dark magical act that violated the sacred boundary between life and death. After being a witness and an isolated victim (Harry is truly alone among the Death Eaters in this graveyard), he transforms back into the heroic warrior and bravely fights for himself, just like how he did earlier when he fought against the Basilisk and Riddle's diary. Harry does not break down mentally or physically, and the protagonist's resilience is a conscious choice from Rowling to reinforce the idea that even in the most hopeless situations, we must never give up. We must fight until the very end, and we have to face our death with dignity. Harry accepts his destiny but does not escape from the graveyard alone. Due to the spell called *Priori Incantatem*, the spirits of people murdered by Voldemort appear, and Harry's parents are among them. The spirits (I intentionally do not call them ghosts, since they do not linger around like Nearly Headless Nick, the Bloody Baron and others), help him disappear from the cemetery, providing Harry time to escape with the portkey while they slow down Voldemort. The spirits' reappearance is symbolic: they come back to haunt the murderer. Just like in the case of Grimmauld Place 12, evil deeds are destined to be discovered, and in this chapter the victims step through the boundary of life and death and help Harry outsmart Voldemort.

2.3 Moaning Myrtle's Bathroom

Opened and sealed by Salazar Slytherin himself, the Chamber of Secrets is reachable through a mundane school bathroom, which belongs to an annoying ghost called Moaning Myrtle. Harry, Ron and Hermione discover this haunted location during their second school year, while

brewing Polyjuice Potion. Interacting with Myrtle, a deceased student's ghost, who actually died in this bathroom, means that Harry talks to a victim. In fact, Myrtle was one of Voldemort's earliest victims. By killing Myrtle with the basilisk, the young Tom Riddle did not just take away a life of one of his schoolmates, but he was able to start the process of Horcrux-making and hide a piece of his soul in the diary.

Myrtle is bound to this location, however, she does not cherish many happy memories about it, as she was bullied, ostracised and murdered in Hogwarts. ““My life was nothing but misery in this place and now people come along ruining my death!”” (*HPCHS* 165). She is a constantly complaining and crying ghost girl. According to *A History of Ghosts, Spirits and the Supernatural*, the trope of the Weeping Woman is a recurring version of female ghosts, especially in Central and South America, and they represent “a sign of something being terribly wrong”, and they are “harbingers of doom” (Henessy et al 132), and tend to appear close to lakes, rivers and to other wet places. Myrtle is guarding the broken-down, damp toilet and she is seen by Hogwarts students and staff members as a nuisance, a joke, which is a grotesque example of the writer's humour, but there is a reason why Rowling must have softened Myrtle's trauma.

Since the Harry Potter books are marketed as children's literature volumes, it is understandable that the profoundness and sinisteress of Myrtle'd tragedy is not properly depicted in a dark and stark tone, but rather diluted with amusing sidefacts, like Myrtle having an irritating personality, or her location, as she haunts a decaying bathroom. This place is shunned by the students because of Myrtle, and this is why the golden trio comes here to brew the Polyjuice Potion, away from prying eyes. It is a successful tactic from Hermione's side, but coming frequently here has two important consequences: Harry, Ron and Hermione have to face mortality, and a haunted place gives them safety and freedom to save the school from the monster that is hidden in the Chamber.

The narrative function of the bathroom and its guardian ghost is that they are bridges between the castle and its ancient underworld. The Chamber of Secrets opens from here through a copper sink marked with a tiny snake decoration (*HPCHS* 317). Harry's and Ron's bravery is strengthened by the fact that they willingly enter to into the darkness beneath the bathroom to save Ginny, even though Lockhart, the hypocritical DADA teacher is too afraid to descend into the realm of possible danger. Harry's moral compass is once again solidified, and he proved to be more heroic than an adult. In fact, Harry's actions show that if you treat an ostracised ghost with patience and dignity, you can get the information you need. Tom Riddle used this bathroom to commit a murder. Harry's trio, however, brewed a potion here, so the

protagonist was able to save a life, even if he had to outsmart a professional fraud and befriend an annoying ghost.

3. Gothic Villains

Dumbledore teaches Harry about the nature of magic and claims that magic is not good or bad. We have a choice to decide what we do with our power and abilities, and this decision shows what we truly are (*HPCHS* 352). Bellatrix and Voldemort both prove Dumbledore's thesis, and they choose to embrace the moral darkness. They are two different versions of Gothic antagonists that embody transgression. Bellatrix is the Madwoman, driven by blind obsession, passion and zealotry. Voldemort is the cold, calculating Double, Harry's shadow version, who represents what the boy could have been if Harry had chosen the wrong path. But they also possess many other characteristics related to Gothic, and these features will be analysed in the following subchapters.

3.1 Bellatrix Lestrange: Madwoman, Anti-Mother, Dark Mentor

"I am and was the Dark Lord's most loyal servant. I learned the Dark Arts from him, and I know spells of such power that you, pathetic little boy, can never hope to compete" (*HPOD* 746). Bellatrix defines herself through the subservient relation to her Master, claiming that she is the protégé of Voldemort. With this Gothic manifesto she represents the dangerous, blind loyalty, and the thirst for forbidden knowledge. The text does not explicitly mention that she is the only female Death Eater, but we can assume that she might be the only one, given the fact that when Voldemort summoned his cronies to the Riddle's graveyard in the fourth book, all of the people were men, and Narcissa Malfoy did not appear alongside her husband, Lucius (*HPGF* 547). Bellatrix was imprisoned at that time in Azkaban, which is the isolated fortress - prison for witched and wizards, where soul-sucking dementors guard the cells, driving the inmates to madness. Having been imprisoned here for more than a decade and exposed to the whims of the dementors, she must have lost her mind, at least partially. Not completely, but psychologically she had been exposed to a very damaging force. Like Sirius, Bellatrix also had a gleam of hope to obsess over. Sirius knew that he was innocent, this is why he did not become crazy. "That wasn't a happy thought, so the Dementors couldn't suck it out of me... but it kept me sane knowing who I am..." (*HPPA* 393). Sirius admitted that unlike others, he survived mentally because of his Animagus skills. He turned into a dog, so the dementors could not eat up his emotions and thoughts (*HPPA* 394). Considering Sirius's argument, we can believe that

Azkaban caused more harm to Bellatrix than to him, but she did not break completely inside the prison, because she believed that Voldemort would return to power and she was waiting for this moment. She remains loyal but mentally somewhat broken. This portrayal of the loyal but entrapped servant with a fragmented mental state exemplifies the Madwoman Trope. Bellatrix's unwavering loyalty towards Voldemort was shared by her Death Eater husband, the lesser-known Rodolphus. They served the Dark Lord and tortured the Longbottoms together. Such devotion to Voldemort was unprecedented, and it led to their imprisonment. After the resurrection ritual, he summons his Death Eaters and ponders about the absence of Bellatrix and Rodolphus.

“‘The Lestranges should stand here’, said Voldemort quietly. ‘But they are entombed in Azkaban. They were faithful. They went to Azkaban rather than renounce me...’” (*HPGF* 547). This statement in the graveyard expresses the expected behaviour pattern, and Voldemort acknowledges the Lestranges' unquestionable devotion and promises a reward. Choosing imprisonment over betrayal means that Bellatrix and her husband risked their saintly but refused to disown their Master. This is how Bellatrix exemplifies the modern version of the Gothic Madwoman trope. The famous trope of the entrapped Madwoman originates mainly from two literary works: Ann Radcliffe's *The Mytseries of Udolpho* and Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*. According to Laurence Talairach-Vielmas, the Madwoman is a resilient and evolving trope, “one of the most potent images of Gothic fiction” (Talairach-Vielmas 32). It has changed and expanded during the centuries of literary tradition. First, the Madwoman trope served as a moral cautionary tale in the 18th and 19th centuries about what could possibly happen if a woman is too defiant, too curious, stubborn, emotional or sexual in the eyes of the patriarchal society. The main message of these narratives is that if you let your emotions override your reason, you become insane, a feverish, hysterical, ghost-like creature. I argue that behind all these cautionary tales hides the visceral fear from women with agency and passion, since dead and passive women with no desires and ambitions mean no threat for the patriarchal society, and they are easier to control.

Talairach-Vielmas claims that in the 1800s, hysteria and madness was a common medical diagnosis used to silence women who suffered from depression, had academic ambition or rejected traditional gender roles, like marrying someone and being a submissive wife. Through this form of labelling, these women and literary female characters were dehumanised. *The Yellow Wallpaper* (1892) brought about the narrative shift showing madness from the female protagonist's perspective, stating that the confinement and the rest cure are what drive women literally mad, not their strong emotions. After the tradition of fainting,

broken-hearted, cataleptic madwomen, Bellatrix Lestrange is a refreshing new figure who embraces her madness as a form of dark power. She is not a passive damsel in distress like her literary predecessors, in fact, she is the modern version of the Madwoman Gothic trope, who unapologetically weaponises her mental instability. Like Charlotte Brontë's Bertha Mason, , Bellatrix was also imprisoned, likes to set buildings on fire and has a faded, twisted beauty and a decaying noble background.

She is a sadistic witch, a firm believer in Voldemort's supremacist ideology of blood purity. If we accept Stojanović's idea that she intentionally killed Sirius too, and not just Nymphadora Tonks, we might suggest that she is on a quest to take revenge on the traitors of the Black family. Bellatrix's character gives suspense to the narrative, as she is in Azkaban during most of the plot, but there are rumours about her viciousness. She breaks out from the prison in the fifth book and becomes part of the Death Eater team commissioned to collect the Prophecy from Harry in the Ministry. While Voldemort is the mastermind who operates from the shadows, Bellatrix is always visible, always in the frontline after her escape from prison. She is present in the attack in the Ministry, in the Astronomy Tower when Snape kills Dumbledore. She is the one who kills Dobby, tortures Hermione in the Malfoy Manor, and she fights against the Order in the Battle of Hogwarts. So, she is present in every major clash and becomes the agent of chaos. She is the loose cannon among the Death Eaters. As an impulsive and cruel person, she enjoys torturing others, therefore her presence raises the stakes from danger to lethality. Lucius reminds her what the task is, and it is the Dark Lord who should kill Harry. Her character serves as a clear example of dark, destructive feminine archetypes, when her cruelty and obsession deprive her from her sanity and humanity.

Although *The Cursed Child* introduces us Delphi, the secretly kept daughter of Bellatrix and Voldemort, Bellatrix represents the Anti-Mother in the plot of the first seven volumes. Jeanne Hoeker LaHaie argues that there is a clear dichotomy regarding adult female characters in the Harry Potter books: they are either nurturing, good, mother-like figures or the complete opposite. She claims that younger female characters, like Luna, Hermione or Ginny have more potential to become whatever they want (brave, smart, athletic, dreamy, etc.) and remain versatile, but after a female character reaches maturity, she becomes defined by her usefulness, her ability to help and nurture the protagonist (LaHaie 125). Bellatrix is the antithesis of these mother-like figures, like Lily Potter, who sacrifices herself for her son. In the opening chapters of *The Half-Blood Prince*, Bellatrix and her sister, Narcissa represent two conflicting approaches to the imminent war. Their interaction with Snape at Spinner's End shows the differences between the two characters. Narcissa and Bellatrix have similar upbringing and

ideological background, however, they have different opinions regarding the Dark Lord's orders. Knowing that Draco was chosen to kill Dumbledore, Narcissa wants to defy Voldemort. She comes to Snape as a desperate mother who wants to protect her son from a suicidal mission, whereas Bellatrix sees this task as a prestigious honour and considers her sister weak and contemptible for asking Snape's intervention. "'You should be proud!' said Bellatrix ruthlessly. 'If I had sons, I would be glad to give them up to the service of the Dark Lord!'" (*HPHBP* 39).

Bellatrix's role here is more than just being a counterpoint to her sister. Bellatrix's presence in this chapter deepens the weight of the agreement by railroading the reluctant Snape into the Unbreakable Vow. She becomes the "Bonder" (*HPHBP* 40) turning the private plea into a lethal promise. Bellatrix does not want to rescue her nephew. She did not come to Spinner's End to save Draco. Her main goal is to stop Cissy or corner Snape, to ensure that there is no middle ground, and Snape must be loyal to Voldemort's circles and make sure that the job will be done, either by Snape or Draco, but in the end the wish of the Dark Lord must be realised.

Even her voice, physical presence and attitude reinforce the idea of the Madwoman and the Anti-Mother tropes. Bellatrix's character represents the uncanny through her unique "mock baby voice" (*HPOP* 746) each time she wants to torture someone. By using a childish voice before committing acts of extreme violence, she reinforces the idea of being an anti-mother. She is not a little girl, but a experienced torturer, and from this respect her representation as a Madwoman trope is similar to creepy dolls. Her total submission to Voldemort is depicted through her use of voice: sheepish, whispering and soft-spoken, and languishing when she is around Voldemort, and "her eyes swam with tears of gratitude again" (*HPDH* 9).

Bellatrix is not nurturing and good-hearted, but she teaches Harry something very important. She brings about a watershed moment in Harry's life when he deliberately acts against his moral compass. She gave a piece of advice to Harry about the nature of Unforgivable Curses after a boy's failed attempt to jinx her, following Sirius's death. "'You need to *mean* them, Potter! You need to really want to cause pain – to enjoy it...'" (*HPOP* 746 emphasis in the original). Harry recalls her mocking lesson, her dark echo years later, when casting the Cruciatus on Amicus Carrow, a Death Eater, who spat McGonagall in the face during the Battle of Hogwarts. Harry emerges from under the Invisibility Cloak, uses dark magic to protect his teacher and punish Carrow, because he was fuelled by anger and love at the same time. "'I see what Bellatrix meant' said Harry, the blood thundering through his brain, 'you need to really mean it.'" (*HPDH* 483). In this chapter Bellatrix is not present, but she functions as a sort of invisible dark mentor. Her haunting thought pushed Harry into a violent deed, which is very

different from his heroic character. Using an Unforgivable Curse means that Harry momentarily stepped into the field of villains, and it caused a moral dissonance with his identity. This subversion of the heroic archetype Harry usually embodies shows that the trauma caused by Bellatrix led to the permanent loss of innocence, as Harry used this dark spell on purpose, so it was not the impulsive rage of a child, but the conscious, premeditated decision of an adult.

Despite being a powerful witch, Bellatrix Lestrange is not invincible. She is not a positive, mother-like character like Lily Potter, Minerva McGonagall or the textbook example of mothers, Molly Weasley. Bellatrix was raised together with Narcissa, but she exemplifies completely different values than her sister, the Death Eater wife Narcissa Malfoy. Bellatrix can be considered as the antithesis of maternal archetypes, therefore, according to the traditional values of the Harry Potter world, Bellatrix must fail. Molly eventually kills her during the Battle of Hogwarts by protecting her daughter, Ginny (*HPDH* 602). Bellatrix's death is a narrative necessity, which is symbolic: it shows the triumph of traditional female values over the destructive nature of blind obsession and thirst for power. Her story is a cautionary tale of what can happen when the darker side of one's personality takes over and makes decisions, and in this regard, she is similar to her beloved Master.

3.2 Voldemort: Monster and Uncanny Double

“I, who have gone further than anybody along the path that leads to immortality.” (*HPHBP* 469 emphasis in the original) Voldemort is the quintessential Gothic villain, who is completely devoid of humanity. His story is a Faustian narrative where the antagonist seeks forbidden knowledge and tries to defy mortality. To become immortal, Voldemort splits his soul into fragments by murdering people (including his own Muggle father and grandparents), and hides these soul-fragments into objects, dark magical containers called Horcruxes. The spine of this subchapter is Jeffrey Jerome Cohen's *Seven Theses*, where Cohen lists criteria regarding monsters and their characteristics. Cohen's work helps us understand the nature of monsters and proposes a set of characteristics, which are all relevant if we analyse Voldemort. Firstly, he claims that “the monster is an embodiment of a certain cultural moment” (Cohen 4), meaning that every culture produces its own monsters, its own villains, and these creatures are the projections of the specific culture's fears. Voldemort was created in the 20th century. Even though his rise to power occurred half a century after the Second World War, his operation and type of power function as a scary echo of the fascism and the totalitarian regime, and channels the long-lasting, persistent cultural anxiety which exists in our culture decades after the war.

His main ideology about cleansing the world from Muggle-borns and establishing an elitist society ruled by pureblood witches and wizards is a clear reference to the real horrors of World War II. Calling him “Master” (*HPGF* 544, 548), “My Lord” (*HPGF* 548), and kneeling in front of him, kissing his robes, the Death Eaters behave as if they were servants or slaves.

Harry must face his primary adversary several times before he eventually kills Voldemort. According to Cohen, monsters have a tendency to return, so the recurring confrontation, the cyclical reappearance of Voldemort reinforces Cohen’s theory (5). And it is not enough to simply outsmart Voldemort or defeat him in a duel. The shredded pieces of his soul must also be individually found and destroyed. This is why the process of eliminating him takes a long time and a lot of effort, and destroying the Horcruxes is only possible with very powerful magical objects like the sword of Gryffindor (*HPDH* 563) or the tooth of the basilisk (*HPCHS* 340), or the dangerous and cursed Fyendfire (*HPDH* 519).

Furthermore, Cohen argues that the monster is always able to escape, it is an elusive creature, like Voldemort. It functions as “[t]he [h]arbinger of [c]ategory [c]risis” (6) and “[d]wells at the [g]ates of [d]ifference”, meaning that it exists in a liminality, in an otherness regarding soul and body. As he cuts his soul into seven, his body gradually transforms from the good-looking Tom Riddle into a monstrous figure, reinforcing the idea that evil deeds cannot be hidden. The text of the seven volumes depicts him several times as “snake-like, with slits of nostrils and gleaming red eye” (*HPDH* 3, 604). But sometimes his face is compared to a white “skull” (*HPGF* 541), and his hands and fingers are spidery (*HPGF* 542), “white” (*HPGF* 542), “unnaturally long” (*HPGF* 542). According to Bridget M. Marshall, the idea that “evil can be seen” (Marshall 1) is an important feature of Gothic novels. She writes about phrenology, which is a pseudo-science related to skull patterns, curvatures of the forehead and certain inner characteristics, underscoring the idea that Voldemort’s snake-like face shows that his humanity is consumed by his predatory nature. His “monstrous aberration” (Cohen 7) is a direct consequence of the usage of dark magic and murderous habits. When Harry gets Professor Slughorn’s memory and discovers the secrets of Horcruxes with Dumbledore, the professor explains Voldemort’s bodily mutation to the boy: “Lord Voldemort seem to grow less human with the passing years, and the transformation he had undergone seemed to me to be only explicable if his soul was mutilated beyond the realms of what we might call usual evil...” (*HPHBP* 469).

Cohen observes that the monster is a gatekeeper, a guardian of acceptable boundaries who “[p]olices the [b]orders of the [p]ossible” (Cohen 15), signifying that there are dark taboos in life, warning others not to cross these lines. So, in this respect, a monster is a moral figure

who warns and admonishes through by existing as a negative example. Cohen confirms that the monster is not just a deterrent, but also “attracts” people (16). Voldemort also gathered followers around him, forming an exclusive circle of those who desired power, protection or recognition at any cost. Unlike Harry, the Death Eaters were attracted to violence and unlimited power over others. Voldemort distinguished his followers with a unique tattoo (the Dark Mark, a fusion of a snake and a skull, just like the monstrous and macabre creatures his appearance is associated with) and made his own name taboo.

According to Janet Brennan Croft, each name has “three essential components” (Croft 1): the name itself with its etymology and the emotional background linked to it, the person signified by the name, and finally, the name-giver. Voldemort becomes all of the three, after he openly chooses the dark side and steps into the spotlight. He despises the name he inherited from his Muggle father, so he decided to eradicate it from public consciousness. However, Dumbledore and Harry keep calling him Tom (*HPOP* 749) (*HPDH* 604). Their intention is not just mockery; they just do not want to give in to the taboo-fear Voldemort created around himself. By calling him simply Tom, they take Voldemort off his pedestal. Dumbledore underscores the idea multiple times that we should not be frightened from anybody. “I have never seen any reason to be frightened of saying Voldemort’s name.” (*HPSS* 12). “Call him Voldemort, Harry. Always use the proper name for things. Fear of the name increases fear of the thing itself.” (*HPSS* 320). Croft highlights that different groups use different euphemisms instead of Voldemort’s name. (Croft 5) His followers call him “Dark Lord” (*HPHBP* 39), “My Lord” (*HPDH* 9), “Master” (*HPOP* 750), others refer to him whispering and superstitiously as “You-Know-Who” (*HPOP* 86) or “He Who Must Not Be Named” (*HPSS* 92) (*HPOP* 778).

While in Judaism the avoidance of God’s ineffable name (Brownlee 1) is a sign of ultimate respect towards the divine, in the Wizarding world it is a tool for heighten the dread and keep people in fear. It also has a practical purpose. In *The Deathly Hallows*, Ron scolds Harry and Hermione and explains to them that they should not say Voldemort’s name because “[t]he name has been jinxed”, and uttering it helps Death Eaters locate and track down people (*HPDH* 317). By purposefully avoiding the name, the citizens of the Wizarding World engage in a superstitious and apotropaic (protecting) act of self-defence. Imposing and enforcing this taboo, Voldemort maintains his domineering position in the hierarchy, intensifies collective fear, and, in a Gothic sense, he operates as an uncanny, subverted double for God, while simultaneously embodies Harry’s shadow-self.

To understand better the function of a shadow-self, we must turn to Freud’s theory about the Uncanny, and Cohen’s theses on monsters. According to Cohen, the monster perceives the

world differently and offers an invitation, an escape from the ordinary (7). Voldemort also offers an alternative path for Harry, as a Doppelgänger, a Gothic Double, but Harry chooses to be different from his nemesis. Voldemort and Harry possess many similarities and in *The Chamber of Secrets*, the young Tom Riddle states that “there are strange likenesses” (*HPCHS* 334) between them, regarding skills and appearances. They have a chillingly shared history of orphanhood, exclusion, misunderstanding. They are both half-blood, speak Parseltongue and have a flexible approach towards rules. Despite these similarities, the main difference between Voldemort and Harry lies in their intentions. According to Dimitris Vardoulakis, the Gothic Double emerged during the Romantic era, became a hallmark of the Gothic genre, and they are traditionally related to evil characters (Vardoulakis 1). He also argues that the person is not a unified entity, and there are parts of the personality that just does not fit together, so there is no “absolutism” in self and we have “excess” (Vardoulakis 2) parts of ourselves. Vardoulakis focuses on footnotes of Sigmund Freud’s work, *The Uncanny*, where these excess parts are introduced as things what we “repress” and “reprehend” in ourselves (Freud 10), which means our personality contains certain dark or negative parts what we refuse to be. But, according to Vardoulakis, who quotes Freud, there is no negation in our unconscious (Vardoulakis 2), and there is more to explore about the connection between the Self and the Dark Double than just the differences and the scariness. The philosophical part of his article was about clarifying the chiasmic relationship (intertwined, complementary) between the Self and the Double (Vardoulakis 5).

Therefore, Voldemort and Harry are perfect examples for complex Self and Double, which are difficult to separate, since Voldemort’s soul fragment lives within Harry until the latter sacrifices himself and gets killed, and eventually it is the Horcrux that dies within Harry. The evil, old man’s soul fragment can be separated only by the Killing Curse, and once this line is created, the fragment remains an abject, raw, baby-like creature in the white King’s Cross chapter (*HPDH* 577). Each time Harry defeats Voldemort, the boy reinforces the idea that despite the similarities, he is not like Voldemort, he does not want to become a monster.

There are different actions of cruelty, but the ultimate slippery slope towards monstrosity is killing people. Cohen explains that there are certain borders of human possibility, and if someone transgresses these borders, like how Voldemort transgressed them in the pursuit of forbidden knowledge and immortality, one can transform into a monster. Cohen highlights that the subversion of norms leads to a state of monstrosity, and Voldemort is the mirror of what could have happened to Harry if he were power-hungry, fuelled by greed and revenge. Observing the nature of different kinds of villains, Voldemort is a textbook

example of both psychopaths and Machiavellians. Niccolo Machiavelli argues in *The Prince* that it is “much safer to be feared than loved” (Machiavelli 66), and rulers must “ward off enemies, woo friends, overcome obstacles by force or fraud” (31) and “eliminate enemies likely or certain to attach him” (31). Voldemort does exactly this by intimidating people and trying to build an elitist system related to blood purity. A missed opportunity though, why he did not force his Death Eaters to take the Unbreakable Vow, remains a mystery.

The young Tom Riddle was handsome and charming, yet callous and incapable of empathy and remorse, and treated others as tools to reach his goals. According to Tomas Erikson, who used the popular DISC model to analyse personalities, communication styles and different kind of psychopaths, there are certain common characteristics related to psychopathy. Real psychopaths have Machiavellian tendencies, but they are way more complex than a simple Machiavellian. The primary indicator of psychopathic tendency is an early presence of antisocial, deviant behaviours, which they exhibit before the first major hormonal changes (around the age of twelve). “This can be anything from cruelty to animals and toward other children, to stealing and lying without the slightest concern” (Erikson 25). In Voldemort’s case, the “strangled rabbit” (*HPHBP* 259), the stolen objects (256) and the abused children from the orphanage (259) were the early indicators that Dumbledore did not take too seriously. Growing up, psychopaths become seasoned manipulators. They are cunning (24) with a parasitic lifestyle, and in Voldemort’s case the parasitic existence is shown both in physical and figurative sense. First, by possessing Quirrell’s body (*HPPS* 315), and then later moving in Lucius’s home in Wiltshire, exploiting the Malfoys and making their manor a Death Eater gathering point (*HPDH* 7). Psychopaths tend to have a “grandiose estimation” (Erikson 23) of themselves and they are “classic narcissists” (23). Voldemort also exhibits these traits by thinking he is better than anyone, stands above rules and gives unnecessarily long speeches and mocking remarks (*HPGF* 553).

Conclusion

The presence of Gothic is the core, the heart of the Harry Potter volumes, since death and liminality are important parts of the narrative for many reasons. The recurring Gothic tropes mean far more than just stylistic coating. The narrative depth and the main character’s development are built on these dark Gothic foundations. Spaces of isolation, fear, death and liminality are necessary milestones, catalysts in Harry’s character development, since they help him to overcome obstacles, to discover and master his magical power. The first chapter observes isolated locations both in the Muggle world and in the Wizarding world, highlighting

the controversial nature of these places. All of them contribute to Harry's character development, and the isolation is a formative force in many ways. The Cupboard under the Stairs gives Harry a place to defy, and several other isolated areas provide him with opportunities to learn and grow. The isolation among the Dursleys reflects Harry's initial loneliness and outcast status, but it cannot break him. On the contrary, it makes him eager to learn new places and make new, meaningful friendships. The subversion of the idea about a loving family and domestic safety creates tension, and after the hurdles of un-homing, neglect and abuse, Harry meets his mysterious saviour, Hagrid, who brings about great changes in the protagonist's life. Hagrid guides Harry into the world of magic. The British Wizarding world is a complex and secretive sphere which overlaps the real Great Britain and there are certain locations where the boundary between the two worlds is permeable. It has heterotopian qualities with its own strict rules and functions as an old-fashioned Gothic enclave, avoiding high-tech Muggle inventions. Hogwarts, the haunted castle is the first place where Harry finally feels important, but his unusual new home is perilous, whimsical and safe at the same time. Grimmauld Place 12 is a typical Gothic space with its decaying walls and gloomy rooms filled with shameful ancestral secrets of the Black family. Thanks to this place, Harry gains insight into the lives of dark wizards and sees the consequences of moral decay, but he also learns that darkness can be swept away. The Forbidden Forest is an important isolated and liminal space, a recurring rite of passage in Harry's maturation process.

The second chapter dissects some of the haunted locations: two other liminal places and a graveyard. The enigmatic Veil in the Ministry is where the boundary between the dead and the living is the thinnest. It is the textbook example of Gothic sublime: awe-inspiring yet dangerous, and even knowledgeable wizards like Remus Lupin talk about it very carefully and succinctly. Harry witnesses here Sirius's mysterious death and realises that there are perilous places even in the Wizarding world, which are better not to be tackled with. The Riddle Graveyard with its symbolic yew tree is the place of Voldemort's dark resurrection ritual, and the place where Harry sees Cedric's death. Due to *Priori Incantatem*, the spirits of the murdered victims come back to haunt Voldemort and slow him down while Harry escapes. With this sudden and unexpected spell, Harry realises that no monstrous deed can be hidden. Moaning Myrtle's Bathroom is a special haunted location and the ghost girl's tragedy is not a trifling story. The bathroom acts as a bridge between the castle and the ancient chamber where Salazar Slytherin's monster is confined.

The third chapter focuses on villains. Antagonists like Bellatrix Lestrange and Voldemort are dark archetypes exemplifying different kinds of monstrosity. Bellatrix is a

modern version of the entrapped Madwoman. She is the antithesis of nurturing, good mothers, and unwillingly becomes Harry's dark mentor. Bellatrix functions as an embodiment of sadism and zealotry, and her blind obsession leads to her demise. Compared to Bellatrix's active, frontline-based character, Voldemort is the cold, calculating and elusive example of psychopathy and manipulation. He follows a Faustian trajectory, seeking forbidden knowledge and immortality. He operates from the shadows and has many traits that are common to psychopaths, Machiavellians and narcissists. He is the Gothic Double of Harry, a dark mirror that shows what Harry could have become if he had chosen the wrong path. Within the Gothic framework, both Voldemort and Bellatrix function as externalised projections of fear and they unwillingly provide Harry with moral lessons. Through their lack of remorse and empathy, villains teach Harry what to avoid and refuse in order not to become a monster like them, so they are moral counterpoints for Harry in his maturation process. Their distorted, frightening example leads Harry towards his true self, towards altruism and goodness.

By featuring such Gothic tropes, J. K. Rowling creates a dangerous, yet safe literary environment for readers to tackle inevitable issues of real life, like losses, traumas, and through Harry's example she provides them with a possible solution. The three chapters focus solely on specific recurring elements, such as isolated places, liminality, haunted areas, villains and monsters. With this thesis paper I wanted to prove that Harry's trajectory has a profound and useful connection to Gothic, and the tropes in his story are more than just backdrops or decorations.

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